NEW HARNOMY, USA

A Revolutionary Opera in Three Acts

Comprehensive Overview

A Three-Hour Satirical Work in 48 Musical Numbers

WORKING DRAFT — VERSION 11

I. CONCEPTUAL FOUNDATION

The Central Premise

New Harnomy, USA is a three-hour satirical opera that inverts the structure of Maoist Cultural Revolution model operas to examine how contemporary progressive movements often avoid class analysis while focusing on identity, culture, and discourse. The work functions as both satire and tragedy, with genuine emotional stakes despite absurdist elements.

The opera is set in the fictional city of New Harnomy during Thanksgiving week and follows three main characters representing different aspects of contemporary activist culture.

Title Significance: New Harnomy

The title "New Harnomy" operates on multiple levels of meaning, all of which the characters themselves cannot perceive:

First, the misspelling embeds harm within harmony. The town believes it's building "New Harmony" but creates new harm—new forms of harm disguised as harmony. The very name announces what the characters cannot see: that their project of social harmony produces harm.

Second, the title evokes Robert Owen's New Harmony, Indiana—the failed 1820s utopian socialist experiment that serves as the opera's historical foundation and cautionary tale.

Historical Foundation: Robert Owen's New Harmony, Indiana

In 1825, British industrialist and social reformer Robert Owen purchased the town of Harmony, Indiana, from a German religious group called the Rappites. Owen envisioned a utopian society based on his belief that human character is formed by one's environment—a community where private property was abolished, labor was exchanged for credit at a communal store, and education was the cornerstone of life.

Owen didn't just bring laborers; he brought intellectuals. In 1826, a keelboat arrived carrying some of the most brilliant scientists, educators, and artists of the era—the famous "Boatload of Knowledge." This influx turned New Harmony into a center for pioneering education (establishing the first infant school and first trade school in the U.S.), scientific research (becoming headquarters for the U.S. Geological Survey), and social equality (serving as a hub for early feminist activism and abolitionist thought).

Despite the intellectual fire, the commune struggled with practical realities. By 1827, the experiment as a communal society effectively collapsed due to three fatal contradictions:

Lack of Skilled Labor: The town had plenty of thinkers but not enough experienced farmers and craftsmen who could sustain material production. The intellectuals could theorize about communal living but couldn't actually produce the food, goods, and infrastructure required to survive.

Internal Friction: Constant disagreements over governance and what "equality" should actually look like. The theoretical commitment to egalitarianism fractured when confronted with practical decisions about authority, labor distribution, and resource allocation.

Financial Strain: Owen poured his personal fortune into the project, but the lack of a steady economy made it unsustainable. Without functional production or exchange systems, the community depended entirely on Owen's inherited wealth—the exact class privilege the commune theoretically rejected.

While the communal living aspect failed, the town survived as an intellectual colony. Owen's children stayed and continued his work in science and politics. New Harmony's influence can be traced directly to the founding of the Smithsonian Institution and the advancement of public education in America. Today, New Harmony is a National Historic Landmark—a quiet, artistic town that reflects the high hopes and instructive failures of its 19th-century founders.

The Perfect Historical Mirror: Owen's experiment collapsed because it had "plenty of thinkers but not enough experienced farmers and craftsmen"—exactly Valencia Strong's critique of fictional New Harnomy. The "Boatload of Knowledge" arriving with intellectuals who couldn't sustain themselves materially is the perfect precedent for Summer, Pengold, and Dick's credentialed inability to discuss economics. Owen's genuine utopianism produced real intellectual legacy (the Smithsonian, public education advances) despite communal failure. The fictional characters produce only career advancement and federal grants despite revolutionary rhetoric. The inversion is complete.

American utopian projects have always collapsed into factional infighting and bourgeois pretension. New Harnomy continues this tradition.

Third, the misspelling immediately signals that something is wrong, broken, corrupted—yet it remains subtle enough to seem like a real aspirational American town name. No character ever acknowledges the spelling. To them, it's simply the town name, pronounced "New Harmony." The audience sees what the characters cannot.

The name itself is the thesis statement. The title tells you everything if you're paying attention.

The Wildean Principle

The work operates under a strict creative law: characters must remain completely earnest and oblivious to the ironies surrounding them. There are no winks to the audience, no moments of self-awareness. The comedy emerges from the gap between the characters' passionate sincerity and the absurdity of their positions—exactly as Wilde's characters believe utterly in the importance of being earnest while demonstrating its impossibility.

The Economic Silence

A crucial structural principle governs the opera: the three main characters—Summer Winters, Pengold Heavens, and Dick Suede—never discuss economics or material conditions. They speak of justice, identity, liberation, revolution, and love, but the question of who pays for what, who owns what, and who works for whom remains systematically absent from their discourse.

Only Valencia Strong, the narrator and economic reality principle, addresses material conditions directly. She functions as a Greek chorus of one, commenting on the action while remaining invisible to the principal characters. Her arias punctuate the drama with observations the others cannot hear and truths they cannot speak.

The Selective Lens

Summer, Pengold, and Dick are all well-credentialed from the finest schools—elite prep schools, Ivy League degrees, graduate programs. They are fluent in theory, can write impeccable grant proposals, and know all current terminology and frameworks. They are not ignorant of history in a general sense—they know the outline of American history, European colonialism, the slave trade, the labor movement.

But they interpret everything through a singular lens: colonial domination, systemic oppression, structural violence. This framework illuminates certain truths while rendering others invisible. Most notably, they remain willfully blind to the history of leftist authoritarianism—the Soviet Union, Eastern Europe, Cuba, Cambodia—where revolutionary elites led privileged lives while populations were terrorized, truly oppressed by those who ruled in the name of liberation.

The irony is structural: they critique systems of domination while remaining blind to domination done in liberation's name. They can identify oppression everywhere except in movements that share their vocabulary. They have memorized the terminology of liberation but cannot recognize its corruption when it wears familiar clothes.

II. THE PHILOSOPHICAL LANDSCAPE

"A Framework for Progressive Awakening"

Instead of referencing multiple real philosophers, the opera creates one fictional ur-text that functions as the community's shared scripture—a pastiche of every post-modern progressive cliché compressed into a single revolutionary document.

Throughout the opera, copies of "A Framework for Progressive Awakening" should be visible on stage—on shelves, on tables, carried by characters, stacked in offices, held up during speeches. The book is the sacred object of New Harnomy's progressive culture, displayed like religious scripture. Characters reference it constantly, quote from it in conversation, and use it to establish credentials and win arguments.

The books are mauve. All editions, regardless of publisher or attribution, share this distinctive color—a soft, cultivated purple-grey that suggests both sophistication and accessibility. The color has become synonymous with framework consciousness itself.

In New Harnomy, no one discusses authorship. The question never arises. The Framework is treated as self-evident truth that any correctly conscious person would recognize. To ask who wrote it would reveal that you haven't done the work.

Characters simply call it "the Framework" or "the Bildersatz Framework." When they need to cite it formally, they write "Bildersatz, E.E." with the bureaucratic efficiency of unexamined authority.

The Ten Principles

The Framework contains ten core tenets that New Harnomy's progressive community has internalized as unchallengeable truth:

Principle 1: "The people do not yet know what they need"

The vanguard must guide those not yet conscious of their own liberation. Resistance to guidance is resistance to one's own freedom.

Principle 2: "Harm is structure, not intent"

Individual motivation is irrelevant. The system produces harm regardless of personal belief.

Principle 3: "Silence is complicity"

There is no neutral position. Passivity is a choice with consequences.

Principle 4: "The framework reveals truth"

Those who do not see what the Framework reveals require consciousness-raising.

Principle 5: "Process IS praxis"

The work of having meetings about the work IS the work.

Principle 6: "Discomfort signals growth"

If engagement with the Framework feels bad, it is working.

Principle 7: "Individual conscience is false consciousness"

The voice in your head questioning the collective is the colonizer speaking through you.

Principle 8: "We are building the future"

The destination is glorious though undefined. Trust the Framework.

Principle 9: "Those who question the path oppose the destination"

Critique of methods is opposition to goals. The Framework does not require defense.

Principle 10: "The collective will emerges through correct consciousness"

Submit to discover freedom. The vanguard reveals the collective will.

III. PRINCIPAL CHARACTERS

Summer Winters

Executive Director, The LYSTERIA Coalition for Reproductive Justice / Founder, The Man Bun Collective

Voice Type: Soprano

Class Origins

Summer comes from an affluent, blue-blood New England family—the kind of old money that doesn't need to announce itself. Her ancestors arrived on ships with names, attended the right schools for generations, summer on the Cape. She is, beneath the revolutionary rhetoric, a limousine liberal with impeccable social credentials.

This background shapes everything about her. Her radicalism is a rebellion against her upbringing that never quite escapes it. She knows how to navigate elite spaces because she was raised in them. Her progressive politics are genuine but also socially costless—her family's wealth insulates her from the consequences of any position she takes. She can afford to be revolutionary.

Professional Position

Summer has run the established reproductive rights organization LYSTERIA Coalition for over ten years. Six months ago, she launched The Man Bun Collective—a new initiative under the LYSTERIA umbrella focused on trans masculine gestational care and fertility preservation for people assigned male at birth.

The Man Bun Collective was created specifically to qualify for a $50 million federal grant for "Gender-Affirming Reproductive Healthcare." The application deadline falls right after Thanksgiving, and Summer needs $5 million in city matching funds from Mayor Pengold Heavens to qualify for the federal grant. This financial dependency creates the dramatic engine of the opera's political plot.

On the $5 Million: The amount is deliberately modest in an era of billion-dollar NGO seed funding. This works dramatically in the opera's favor—the smallness of the stakes makes the betrayal more devastating. Summer isn't choosing the Man Bun Collective over Dick for transformative money; she's choosing it for respectable money. The $5 million gets her to the table for the $50 million federal grant, but even that is mid-tier in today's NGO landscape. She's not Faust selling her soul for infinite power—she's a middle manager protecting a line item. The banality makes it worse. Pengold isn't offering her the world; he's offering her enough. Just enough to keep LYSTERIA competitive, just enough to make the Man Bun Collective viable, just enough to keep her in the game. The modesty of the amount reveals the modesty of everyone's actual ambitions—they're not revolutionaries, they're careerists.

Name Significance

The promise of abundance (Summer) turned into barrenness (Winters)—fecundity transformed into sterility, growth into death. The name contains the contradiction that defines her character. She operates during winter (Thanksgiving week), her name's promise perpetually unfulfilled.

Personal History

Summer was married for five years and recently divorced (finalized one year ago). Her marriage fell apart partly due to her decision to undergo irreversible sterilization without consulting her husband—Philip Winters, a classics professor who is an expert on the Peloponnesian War and Athens.

Philip was an academic who valued measured scholarship over performative activism. He studied Athens' democratic hubris and imperial overreach, understood how idealism curdles into tyranny through Thucydides' lens. He wanted a conventional life: children, stability, intellectual partnership. He questioned Summer's increasing radicalization, saw the performative elements she couldn't, asked uncomfortable questions about funding sources and actual impact.

As Summer became more involved in activist culture, the rift grew. He wanted her attention focused on their relationship, not the movement. He wanted children; she postponed, then refused, then got sterilized without consulting him.

His unforgivable sin came after their separation: he published an article questioning NGO effectiveness—nothing targeting Summer specifically, but examining how professionalized activism can become self-perpetuating and disconnected from actual community needs.

The article's core argument used historical parallels:

On Robert Owen's New Harmony: Well-intentioned intellectuals who couldn't sustain material reality. The "Boatload of Knowledge" arrived with theories but no practical skills to make the commune function. The community collapsed because thinking about communal living is not the same as producing the food, goods, and infrastructure required to sustain it.

On Sparta vs. Athens in the Peloponnesian War: "Contemporary progressive organizations increasingly deploy collectivist rhetoric while operating as personal fiefdoms. The 'warm embrace' of collective identity functions as a mechanism of control rather than genuine mutual aid.

Sparta claimed to eliminate individualism in service of collective virtue. In practice, this meant absolute subordination of the individual to state will—helotry disguised as solidarity. The Spartan 'equals' (homoioi) were equal only in their shared submission to the system. The collective became an entity that demanded obedience rather than a framework for cooperation.

Athens fell not because democracy failed, but because democratic rhetoric masked imperial ambition. The Assembly spoke of freedom while demanding tribute. The language of liberation accompanied the practice of domination.

When we see NGOs demanding submission to organizational orthodoxy while calling it 'collective care,' we should recognize the pattern. When dissent is treated as betrayal of the collective, we are recreating the Spartan trap. The warm embrace closes like a fist. The collective that cannot tolerate individual conscience becomes indistinguishable from tyranny.

Thucydides showed us how democracies fall: not through external conquest, but through internal corruption—when rhetoric replaces governance, when idealism curdles into hubris, when the performance of virtue substitutes for its practice."

The article concluded by suggesting that effective community organizing requires material focus, economic analysis, and tolerance for dissent—precisely what many contemporary progressive organizations systematically avoid.

The academic's critique wasn't wrong—and Summer knew it. That's why it was unforgivable.

During Their Marriage

Summer heard earlier versions of this argument during their marriage. When she would come home energized from organizing meetings, talking about building collective power and dismantling individualist ideology, Philip would gently probe:

> *"But who decides what the collective wants? What happens to the person who disagrees with the collective's judgment? How is what you're describing different from enforced conformity?"*

She dismissed these questions as too abstract, too academic, too removed from actual organizing—a convenient intellectual framework for avoiding commitment, cold analysis that missed the emotional reality of community, the kind of liberal hand-wringing that protects privilege.

She needed him to believe in the warm embrace. He kept asking cold questions. The marriage couldn't survive the gap.

Dick's Campaign Against Philip Winters

Dick Suede's PILF organization organized protests at Philip's university, demanding his censure for "harmful rhetoric that delegitimizes community organizing." Student activists, led by Dick, framed the professor as actively harming the movement—a direct violation of Bildersatz's third principle ("Silence is complicity") and ninth principle ("Those who question the path oppose the destination"). Philip's article was treated not as scholarship to be debated but as heresy against the Framework itself.

Dick's rhetoric during the campaign explicitly rejected the Sparta comparison:

"This professor compares our work to Spartan oppression—as if building collective care is the same as military domination. He doesn't understand that what he calls 'submission' is actually liberation from the burden of standing alone. The warm embrace isn't a closing fist—it's the relief of finally belonging. He's so trapped in his individualist framework that he can't imagine genuine collectivity. He sees tyranny because he can't conceive of freely chosen solidarity. Bildersatz teaches us that individual conscience is false consciousness—the colonizer speaking through us. This professor has made himself a mouthpiece for that colonizing voice."

The irony that Dick never sees: he proved Philip's argument by using collective power to silence individual critique of collective power. The warm embrace closed like a fist around the man who warned it would.

The university, not wanting controversy, pressured the professor to resign or face formal review. He was effectively driven from his position.

Dick saw this as defending Bildersatzian orthodoxy from academic delegitimization and protecting Summer (whose ex-husband's critique implicitly questioned her work). He proved his revolutionary credentials through direct action. Dick didn't know—or didn't want to know—that this was Summer's ex-husband. If he learned during the campaign, his reaction was predictable: "He was actively harming the movement. Are you saying he should have been protected because you used to be married? The personal is political. He chose to publish that article. He chose his individualist ideology over solidarity. This is what accountability looks like."

The personal is political; the political erases the personal.

Summer could have warned Dick this was her ex-husband. She could have asked him to stop the campaign. She said nothing. She may have even quietly encouraged it—Philip's critique stung because it was partially true, and destroying his career eliminated the voice asking questions she couldn't answer.

This act of bodily autonomy, framed as revolutionary self-determination, destroyed her most intimate relationship. Her ex-spouse wanted a conventional life; she wanted revolution (or its performance). The sterilization transformed her name from clever wordplay into autobiographical tragedy—she literally enacted the barrenness her name prophesies.

She is still processing whether she's capable of authentic connection or only loves the work. His question haunts her throughout the opera: "What won't you do for the cause?" It's the question she cannot answer, because answering it would require acknowledging limits she has built her identity around denying.

She has now been complicit in destroying two men who loved her—one who questioned the movement, one who believed in it too much. The common thread isn't their positions. It's that protecting them would have required her to sacrifice something she wanted more.

Theoretical Fluency

Summer's office has multiple mauve copies of the Framework prominently displayed—highlighted, annotated, with passages underlined and cross-referenced. She quotes Bildersatz constantly in grant applications, board presentations, and media interviews. She writes as if Bildersatz were reviewing her grant proposals personally.

When defending the Man Bun Collective's mission, she deploys the Framework: "Reproductive healthcare has always been a site of biopower—the state's attempt to regulate which bodies reproduce,

how, and under what conditions. Bildersatz teaches us that harm is structure, not intent. Our work disrupts that regulatory apparatus." When critics question the Collective's lack of actual services, she invokes the Framework's fifth principle: "Process IS praxis. The very act of creating space for these conversations is itself transformative. We're not just providing services; we're destabilizing the normative assumptions that render certain bodies invisible."

The Pengold Complication

Summer has a complicated history with Mayor Pengold Heavens. Four years ago, during his first campaign, they had a drunken encounter that she immediately regretted—the unspoken thing between them ever since. She ran his first city council campaign as political consultant and organizer. They worked intensely together—late nights, strategy sessions, the high of winning. The "work spouse" dynamic developed; everyone joked about it while her actual spouse increasingly resented it.

Now she's trading strategic ambiguity with Pengold for matching funds, and she can no longer tell where the lines are. The $5 million negotiation carries the weight of unresolved history—she cannot tell where strategic ambiguity ends and something else begins because the lines were already blurred before the grants were in play.

The Betrayal

Summer has a scheduled meeting with Pengold to finalize the $5 million matching funds. She arrives early—she's always early, organized, professional. Pengold's office door is slightly ajar. She's about to knock when she overhears:

> **PENGOLD:** *…federal investigators need a name. Someone whose financials won't withstand scrutiny.*
>
> **ANOTHER VOICE (City AG or TWEEEDS operative):** *Suede's organization is a disaster. Misappropriation, missing funds, grant violations. We document it, hand it over, investigation stops there.*
>
> **PENGOLD:** *And PILF's failure looks like individual incompetence, not systemic issues.*
>
> **OTHER VOICE:** *When do we move?*
>
> **PENGOLD:** *Anti-Thanksgiving Feast. Public setting. Maximum impact. He won't see it coming—he thinks I'm protecting him.*

[Pause.]

> **PENGOLD:** *Is the LYSTERIA allocation secure?*
>
> **OTHER VOICE:** *Paperwork's ready. Five million, contingent on…*
>
> **PENGOLD:** *Good. She's earned it.*

Summer stands frozen outside the door. She understands: Dick will be arrested at the festival she helped organize, by the man she's sleeping with, who will then fund her organization. The connection between these facts is obvious.

She could walk in and confront Pengold. She could warn Dick immediately. She could threaten to expose the plan. She could walk away from the money.

Instead: she steps back from the door quietly. She waits sixty seconds. She knocks. She enters as if she heard nothing. She signs the paperwork.

The meeting proceeds professionally. They discuss the Man Bun Collective's programming, the federal grant timeline, the matching fund transfer schedule. Strategic ambiguity maintained.

As she's leaving, Pengold says: "I'm glad we're on the same page, Summer. Everything we've built—it needs protection."

She understands this is both promise and threat. She nods. She leaves.

Her rationalization cascade: "Dick's organization IS poorly managed—maybe this is necessary accountability." "If I warn him, I compromise myself, and then I can't do the work." "The Man Bun Collective serves people who have no other options." "Dick has family money—he'll be fine." "I can't be responsible for protecting everyone." "This is what revolution costs."

Like Kay Corleone asking Michael if he kills people, Summer chooses not to know what she already knows. She doesn't ask Dick "Is it true?" because she doesn't want to hear him confirm his incompetence. She doesn't ask Pengold "Are you setting him up?" because she doesn't want him to confirm the price of her funding.

She maintains plausible deniability until the moment Dick is arrested in front of her—and then it's too late to pretend.

Her calculation is immediate and brutal: warning Dick would reveal that she knows about the plot, which would compromise her relationship with Pengold, which would jeopardize the $5 million matching funds for the Man Bun Collective, which would destroy her chance at the $50 million federal grant. The cause—her cause—requires Dick's sacrifice.

She watches Dick walk into the trap knowing what's coming. The question "What won't you do for the cause?" is answered: she will let a man be destroyed. She will let a man die.

Dramatic Arc

Summer's arc is the opera's moral center. She moves from genuine believer to active collaborator in betrayal. Philip's expertise in the Peloponnesian War creates perfect thematic resonance: Athens' democratic hubris, the disaster of the Sicilian Expedition, Thucydides' cold analysis of how idealism curdles into cynicism—all mirror Summer's trajectory.

By the opera's end, she has become what she once would have denounced. The system didn't corrupt her through force; it corrupted her through incremental accommodations, each one reasonable in isolation, until she found herself complicit in a man's death.

Pengold Heavens

Mayor of New Harnomy, TWEEEDS Party

Voice Type: Baritone

Origins: The Intern Who Watched

Pengold did not inherit his position—he engineered it. At university, he was an obsessive brown-noser and careerist, the student who sat front row, attended every office hour, and memorized his professors' work to quote it back to them in discussion sections. He graduated summa cum laude not through intellectual brilliance but through relentless cultivation of anyone who could advance him.

His political education began as a TWEEEDS summer intern. He watched the party leadership closely—observed how funding decisions were made, how loyalty was rewarded and disloyalty punished, how revolutionary rhetoric provided cover for ordinary patronage operations. He didn't critique this system; he took notes. He learned that ideology was a tool for accumulating power, not a constraint upon it. The true believers were useful but ultimately disposable. Power belonged to those who understood its mechanics.

He ingratiated himself with the leadership, made himself indispensable, and launched his career. Everything since has been the application of lessons learned that summer: how power is accumulated and wielded, how dependency is created, how loyalty is purchased and maintained.

Political Formation

Pengold represents the Ivy-educated progressive in the mold of John Lindsay, Bill de Blasio, and Zohran Mamdani—politicians who deny empirical reality in favor of neo-Marxian social theories, who refuse to compromise with those who do not share their belief systems, and who remain fully convinced of their own correctness regardless of outcomes.

His administration is characterized by a distinctive pattern: failures are never his fault. There is always someone else to blame. When snow goes uncleared, when public drug use proliferates, when school test scores collapse, when garbage accumulates, when homelessness spreads—the fault lies elsewhere. The root cause is always insufficient resources. The City can never have enough revenue. It always needs more.

The guiding principle of Pengold's administration: "The problem IS the solution." The persistent problem justifies the unending stream of grant dollars. Homelessness must never be solved, only managed—because solving it would eliminate the need for next year's $50 million homelessness initiative. School failure must continue—because improved test scores would mean fewer education consultants, fewer intervention programs, fewer jobs for the credentialed class that forms his base. Public drug use must proliferate—because the crisis justifies expanding the harm reduction infrastructure that employs his coalition.

The worse the problem becomes, the more funding it generates. The more funding it generates, the larger the patronage network grows. The larger the network, the more political power Pengold wields. Success would be catastrophic—it would eliminate the justification for the grift.

This is not conscious cynicism on Pengold's part. He genuinely believes he's addressing these issues. He cannot see that his entire system depends on their persistence. The problem IS the solution—the problem provides the moral justification, the funding stream, the employment base, the political capital, and the revolutionary credentials. Solving the problem would eliminate all of these simultaneously.

When critics point out that homelessness has increased despite tripling the budget, Pengold responds that this proves the need for even more resources. When test scores continue falling after implementing expensive new curricula, this demonstrates the depth of systemic inequality requiring further intervention. The failure becomes evidence of insufficient commitment, not failed approach.

Pengold thinks constantly about revenue: how to generate it, which groups should receive it, and what benefit would accrue to him personally—strengthening his revolutionary bona fides, polishing his public image, and supporting his ruthless drive to hold the reins of power.

All of this operates in service of a fundamental belief: that he and his political allies have a monopoly on Truth, and that left to their own devices, the population would make the "wrong" choices. He alone

possesses the hubristic vision to guide the City to its destiny—a destiny undefined, but free of all mechanisms of oppression. He cannot describe what he is building toward, only what he is tearing down.

Theoretical Deployment

Pengold keeps a pristine mauve copy of the Framework on his desk—conspicuously unread, strategically positioned. He uses the Bildersatz text strategically rather than earnestly—it provides intellectual cover for political maneuvers.

When critics challenge his policies, he invokes the Framework's ninth principle: "Those who question the path oppose the destination. The very demand for 'balanced debate' is itself a form of repressive tolerance—creating false equivalence between liberation and oppression." When journalists question his administration's failures, he deploys the Framework's fourth principle: "The framework reveals truth. You're operating within a discourse that naturalizes certain metrics of 'success' that were designed to delegitimize progressive governance." The Bildersatzian sophistication immunizes his positions from criticism by framing all criticism as itself suspect.

The Patronage Machine

As Mayor, Pengold controls New Harnomy's city government and budget. He directs public funding to politically aligned NGOs, creating dependency—classic political machine operations exactly like Boss Tweed's Tammany Hall, all while claiming to represent workers and democracy. He represents the bureaucratic channeling of revolutionary energy into committee meetings and funding allocations.

The TWEEEDS party (Toward Workers' Emancipation, Equity, and Empowerment of Democratic Socialists) is his political vehicle. The acronym carries triple irony: it evokes Boss Tweed (the epitome of political corruption), tweed fabric (prep school, Ivy League, old money aesthetic), and the alphabet soup of contemporary political naming. The grammatical ambiguity of "empowerment OF democratic socialists" reveals that the party empowers itself, not workers.

Pengold does not know who Boss Tweed was. He has never studied the history of machine politics he now practices. He knows the terminology of liberation but not the patterns of exploitation he replicates. The summer intern who watched and learned has become the boss, operating the same machinery with new slogans.

The Summer Obsession

Pengold has been fixated on Summer Winters for four years—since their drunken encounter on election night. He has supported her career and organization ever since: a mixture of genuine attraction, unspoken apology, and strategic positioning to keep her close and dependent. He waited through her separation and divorce with calculated patience. Now that she's available, he sees the festival as his opportunity.

He controls the $5 million city matching funds that Summer needs for her federal grant. This is not coincidence. He has been preparing this leverage for months, knowing the Man Bun Collective's federal deadline would create dependence. He had a plan. He was patient. He was strategic.

Then Dick Suede entered the picture.

Pengold learned about the affair almost immediately. New Harnomy's progressive community is small; everyone knows everyone's business despite performative discretion. Someone at a coalition meeting mentioned seeing Summer and Dick together. A TWEEEDS operative noticed them leaving an event. The signals were unmistakable.

Pengold did nothing. He didn't confront Summer. He didn't challenge Dick. He watched. He calculated. He waited.

Because Pengold understands what Dick does not: that Summer's affair with Dick makes her more dependent on Pengold, not less. She needs the funding. She needs the political cover. She needs Pengold's machine to protect her organization. Her relationship with Dick is a liability she cannot afford to acknowledge publicly—it would undermine her professional credibility, compromise her negotiations with Pengold, and expose the personal entanglements that make her vulnerable.

Pengold has been watching Summer navigate the affair and the funding negotiations simultaneously. He sees her trying to keep them separate, trying to maintain professional boundaries with him while sleeping with Dick. He finds it almost endearing—her belief that she can compartmentalize, that she can manage both relationships without consequences.

He lets her believe it. Because the longer she believes she can have both—Dick's passionate revolutionary romance and Pengold's $5 million—the more trapped she becomes. Every day the affair continues, every meeting she has with Pengold while sleeping with Dick, every grant discussion that carries unspoken weight—it all binds her more tightly to Pengold's machine.

The Dick Suede Problem

Pengold's response to Dick operates on multiple levels. There is romantic rivalry—Dick threatens his patient campaign for Summer, but more importantly, Dick represents everything Pengold planned for and now sees slipping away. There is class resentment—Dick embodies everything Pengold had to work for but was handed by birth. The trust fund, the casual radicalism, the expensive "vintage" aesthetic, the ability to fail without consequence. Pengold clawed his way up from summer intern; Dick descended from inherited wealth to play revolutionary.

But the deepest resentment is this: Dick got Summer's attention without strategy, without patience, without calculation. Dick simply showed up, charming and naive and passionate, and Summer fell for the performance. Pengold has been strategically positioning himself for four years—supporting LYSTERIA, attending her events, carefully maintaining just enough distance to seem respectful of her marriage while staying close enough to remain relevant. He waited through her separation, through her divorce, through her recovery. He built dependency. He created leverage.

And Dick, who has no strategy at all, who operates purely on instinct and privilege, walks in and takes what Pengold has been working toward for years.

That's what Pengold cannot forgive. Not the affair itself, but the ease of it. Dick doesn't understand what he has. Dick thinks Summer loves him for his revolutionary commitment, his Bildersatzian fluency, his passionate organizing. Dick doesn't see that he's simply convenient—young enough to be flattering, radical enough to be validating, naive enough to never ask hard questions.

Pengold sees exactly what Dick is to Summer. And that makes Dick's destruction not just strategic, but personal.

Dick has been a loyal supporter of Pengold, repeatedly donating to TWEEEDS and to Pengold personally. He has been promised the Grassroots Resilience and Innovation Fund for Transformation (GRIFT) grant that will pull PILF out of immediate insolvency. Dick is naive about Pengold's capacity for treachery—he believes loyalty flows both directions. He does not understand that in machine politics, loyalty flows upward but protection flows according to calculation.

Dick doesn't even know he's Pengold's rival. He thinks Pengold is his ally, his mentor, his political patron. When Dick mentions Summer in conversation with Pengold—casually, proudly, assuming everyone knows and approves—Pengold smiles and nods. He asks how the Man Bun Collective launch is going. He mentions the matching funds are "moving through channels." He keeps Dick talking, keeps Dick confident, keeps Dick completely oblivious to the trap being constructed around him.

Because Pengold understands something Dick never learned: in machine politics, the most dangerous person is the one who smiles while sharpening the knife.

The Sacrifice

When federal investigators begin circling New Harnomy, Pengold sees his opportunity. Dick Suede becomes the sacrifice to the federal oversight gods—a contained scandal that protects the broader system while eliminating a romantic rival. The summer intern who learned how power works wields it against the trust fund kid who never had to learn anything.

Dick's destruction is Pengold's masterpiece of machine politics: appearing to enforce accountability while preserving corruption, removing a rival while looking like a reformer, sacrificing an individual to protect a system.

"They, the People" – Pengold's Aria

One of Pengold's major musical numbers is "They, the People"—his love song to the downtrodden masses who need his protection and guidance. The aria reveals his fundamental paternalism: left to their own devices, the people would be led astray by demagogues who do not have their best interests at heart. He alone, with his Ivy League credentials and Bildersatzian consciousness, can guide them to liberation.

The aria is filled with genuine emotion—Pengold truly loves "the people" in the abstract. But the language systematically others them: "they" need saving, "they" require education, "they" must be protected from their own false consciousness. The people are never subjects of their own liberation, always objects of his enlightened administration.

The dramatic irony: Pengold positions himself as the vanguard protecting the people from demagogues—while operating as a demagogue himself. He warns against those who don't have the people's best interests at heart—while running a patronage machine that enriches his coalition at the people's expense. He speaks of empowering the voiceless—while ensuring they remain dependent on his system.

Musical structure: The aria should feel genuinely moving, with soaring melody and orchestral swell. Pengold's love for "the people" is sincere in its own way—he genuinely believes he's their champion. The music mirrors his self-perception as benevolent protector. Only the lyrics reveal the paternalism: the repeated use of "they" creating distance, the language of guidance and protection rather than partnership, the assumption that he knows better than the people themselves what they need.

Valencia's interlude afterward: She translates the aria into economic reality. "He loves them so much he'll never let them speak for themselves. He'll protect them right into permanent dependence. The people don't need saving—they need him to get out of the way."

The song encapsulates Pengold's entire worldview: he is the self-appointed intellectual vanguard of the people, championing them against forces of oppression while never recognizing that his own system has become one of those forces. He others the very people he claims to serve, positioning himself as the educated elite who must guide the masses to consciousness they cannot achieve on their own.

It’s Bildersatz’s first principle made flesh: "The people do not yet know what they need." Pengold has internalized this completely. He loves the people. He would do anything for the people. Except trust them. Except listen to them. Except let them determine their own needs.

Psychological Profile

Pengold is so controlled he cannot acknowledge anything outside his calculated narrative. He cannot separate romantic desire from political ambition—he doesn’t know if he loves Summer or what she represents. He has performed strategic positioning so long that he has lost access to any authentic self beneath the performance.

Unlike Dick, who doesn’t know he’s performing, Pengold knows exactly what he’s doing—which makes his condition more tragic. He chose this. He built this. And now he cannot find the person who existed before the construction began.

His crisis throughout the opera: "I don’t know if I love Summer or what she represents or the fantasy I built." Four years of waiting—was it love? Entitlement? Strategy? He cannot separate them.

He is the modern Boss Tweed of New Harnomy. He would not understand the comparison.

Dick Suede

Community Organizer and Political Activist / Founder, The People’s Intersectional Liberation Front (PILF)

Voice Type: Tenor

Origins: "Little Dickie"

Within his family, Dick was always known as "Little Dickie"—the diminutive that never stopped diminishing. The family regarded him as soft, unserious, the heir who would squander rather than build. His revolutionary posture is partly an attempt to become someone other than Little Dickie, to prove he can make his mark independent of the family name and fortune.

He became a progressive primarily to get laid in college. It worked. The Bildersatz quotes, the performed vulnerability about privilege, the Framework’s language of collective awakening—all of it was initially instrumental, a seduction strategy that happened to come with a community, an identity, and eventually a career. He discovered that fluency in the Framework made him irresistible to a certain kind of idealistic young woman—that performing Bildersatzian consciousness was the most effective pickup technique he’d ever found.

He always had doubts about the authenticity of the progressive agenda. Unlike Summer, who is a true believer who may have lost her way, Dick never fully believed. He adopted the politics because they were useful and continued because they kept working. His doubts about the movement mirror his doubts about himself.

The People’s Intersectional Liberation Front

After college, Dick secretly established PILF using trust fund revenues—his rebellion against family wealth funded entirely by family wealth. The contradiction is invisible to him but obvious to everyone else. He wanted to make his mark independent of his family, but he used their money to do it. He can never escape what he’s trying to escape.

PILF's mission statement speaks of "community liberation through intersectional resistance." In practice, this means: a weekly reading group studying the Framework; "know your rights" trainings that are poorly attended; mutual aid programs that distribute goods purchased with Dick's trust fund and city grants; direct action coordination that mostly involves planning meetings; and "decolonization workshops" offered to other NGOs and city agencies.

The organization's office has multiple mauve copies of the Framework prominently displayed—highlighted, annotated, passages underlined in competitive colors by different staff members trying to demonstrate superior consciousness. These books are genuinely read in the weekly discussion groups, though the discussions tend toward competitive Bildersatzian display rather than practical application.

PILF has been grossly mismanaged. Someone at PILF—a staff member, a volunteer with access, maybe even multiple people—has been systematically stealing. This is realistic: poorly managed nonprofits with charismatic but inattentive leaders are prime targets for internal theft. Dick didn't notice because he trusted everyone (revolutionary solidarity!), didn't actually understand the Framework's denser passages, his trust fund covered early gaps so he didn't track closely, and he was too busy performing revolutionary leadership to audit.

Dick finally discovered the shortfall shortly before the opera begins—prompted by the upcoming GRIFT grant application requiring financial documentation. Not just "we're overspent" but "money is missing and I don't know where it went."

He can't report this because it would expose his own negligence, destroy PILF before the GRIFT grant arrives, confirm everything his family said about "Little Dickie," and mean admitting he failed at the one thing he built to prove them wrong.

His rationalization cascade: "I need to cover this temporarily until the GRIFT grant comes through." "These businesses/institutions benefit from gentrification/patriarchy anyway." "This is just redistributing resources the system stole first." "The academic is actively harming our movement with their critiques." "Once we're solvent again, we can focus on real work." "I'm not stealing—I'm organizing community contribution."

The books are a disaster, grant requirements have been ignored, funds have been allocated according to whim rather than program. Dick desperately needs new city grant funding—specifically the GRIFT grant Pengold has promised him—to keep the lights on and cover the losses. A failure of PILF would be a shattering blow to his ego—confirmation of everything his family believed about Little Dickie.

The Shakedown Campaign

PILF's primary activity in the run-up to the Thanksgiving rally is a "donation" campaign targeting local institutions and businesses in the name of community solidarity. In practice, this is an extractive shakedown: PILF representatives visit small businesses, religious institutions, and local academics, soliciting "voluntary" contributions to a community fund that flows back into PILF's operations. The targets are framed as agents of social oppression—gentrifiers, enforcers of patriarchal tradition, or purveyors of harmful ideas—but the reality is considerably smaller and more vulnerable than the rhetoric suggests.

The targets form a revealing pattern. A family-run bodega and a small independent restaurant are visited as "gentrification enablers"—in reality, the most genuinely community-embedded businesses in the neighborhood, owned by immigrants who cannot fight back the way a corporation could. A Black church and a local parish are targeted as "regressive institutions perpetuating patriarchal

structures"—organizations with far deeper roots in actual community resistance than PILF possesses. And a local academic who has published work questioning whether NGO-led programs actually serve the communities they claim to help is the most dangerous target of all, because this person is making the intellectual case against PILF's entire model. The campaign against the academic is not just retaliation—it is existential. If the argument gains traction, the grift collapses.

Dick is the one knocking on doors. He is charming, earnest, passionate—he genuinely believes he is doing meaningful work. The bodega owner, the church treasurer, the small landlord can all see exactly what is happening. Dick cannot see that they see him, because he is too deep inside the narrative.

The progression we see on stage across Act I: Early in the festival, Dick is charming and persuasive, genuinely believes in "voluntary contribution." Mid-festival, targets are resisting; Dick becomes more insistent, deploys heavier Bildersatzian rhetoric. Late festival, Dick is explicitly threatening—social media exposure, protest targeting, "we'll remember who stood with us." Valencia watches this transformation, sees the desperation underneath, and recognizes the exact moment Dick crosses from organizer to extortionist.

There is something Raskolnikov-like in this: Dick has constructed an ideological framework that permits him to see these targets as legitimate, the way Raskolnikov convinced himself the pawnbroker was a net negative on the world. The grandiosity of the self-justification versus the smallness and vulnerability of the actual target is where the real horror lives.

Dick is not entirely unaware of what PILF has become. He intellectually knows the targeting is disproportionate, but he has rationalized it as "the cost of the struggle." He has watched other leaders try to moderate movements and get destroyed by them. He tells himself the targeting will stop once the "real work" begins—but the real work never quite begins, because the targeting is the work now. He lacks the force of will to rein it in, partly because doing so would mean confronting what PILF actually is, and partly because PILF's energy is where his identity lives. He is the person who says "I don't condone it, but I understand it."

Theoretical Performance

The Core Philosophy: Warm Embrace vs. Cold Individualism

Dick's central theoretical framework, which he deploys constantly in speeches, workshops, and conversations, is the contrast between "the warm embrace of collectivism" and "the coldness of rugged individualism." He grounds this in Bildersatz's seventh principle—"Individual conscience is false consciousness"—and the tenth—"Submit to discover freedom."

His version of the argument goes: "The whole American experiment is built on this myth of the rugged individual—the self-made man, the pioneer, the entrepreneur. But that's just ideology masking exploitation. Bildersatz shows us that real freedom comes from collective care, from the warm embrace of community, from subordinating ego to the common good. That's what PILF is building—a space where individualism dies and collective flourishing begins."

When explaining why small businesses must contribute to the community fund: "These shop owners think 'it's my store, my profit, my right.' That's the disease. Bildersatz calls it false consciousness. They need to understand they're part of a larger whole, that their individual 'rights' are less important than collective need. We're teaching them the warm embrace of solidarity. Once they stop resisting, once they accept their place in the collective, they'll feel the relief of not having to stand alone."

When defending the targeting of religious institutions: "These churches claim to serve community, but they're actually fortresses of individualist ideology—personal salvation, individual conscience, the soul standing alone before God. That's atomization dressed as spirituality. Real community means collective conscience, collective judgment, collective accountability. Bildersatz's seventh principle is clear: individual conscience is false consciousness. We're offering them something better than their cold individualist theology."

The Irony Dick Cannot See

Dick champions collective submission while living on a trust fund (ultimate individualist wealth accumulation), running an NGO he controls completely (personal fiefdom), making unilateral decisions about targeting and tactics, using collective rhetoric to justify personal power, and demanding others subordinate their judgment to his vision.

What he calls "the warm embrace" is actually submission to his organizational demands. What he calls "collective flourishing" is conformity to his ideology. What he calls "liberation from individualism" is the elimination of individual resistance.

He is building Sparta while calling it liberation. He demands helotry while calling it solidarity.

The Ex-Husband's Ghostly Critique

Summer's ex-husband—the Peloponnesian War scholar—made this exact critique in his article questioning NGO effectiveness. His argument included:

> *"Contemporary progressive organizations deploy collectivist rhetoric while operating as personal fiefdoms. The 'warm embrace' of collective identity functions as a mechanism of control. Sparta claimed to eliminate individualism; it actually eliminated individual freedom. The Spartan system demanded absolute subordination to state will, calling it virtue while practicing terror. When we see NGOs demanding submission to organizational orthodoxy while calling it 'collective care,' we should recognize the pattern. Athens fell not because democracy failed, but because democratic rhetoric masked imperial ambition. When the collective becomes an entity that demands submission rather than a framework for mutual aid, we have recreated the Spartan trap. The warm embrace closes like a fist."*

Dick's Response

Dick organized the protest campaign that destroyed this man's career. He never engaged with the intellectual argument. He treated the critique as a personal attack on the Framework—a violation of Bildersatz's ninth principle. He used collective power—student activists, PILF members, social media pressure—to eliminate individual dissent.

The irony is perfect: Dick proved Philip's point by using collective force to silence individual critique of collective force.

Summer's Position

Summer heard her ex-husband make this argument during their marriage. She dismissed it as too abstract, too academic, too removed from actual organizing—a convenient intellectual framework for avoiding commitment, cold analysis that missed the emotional reality of community.

Then she heard Dick make the opposite argument—grounded in Bildersatz, delivered with passionate conviction—and found it viscerally compelling, emotionally satisfying, validating of her work. Warm where Philip was cold. Present where Philip was distant.

She chose the warm embrace. She rejected the cold analysis. Now she's trapped in the closing fist and cannot admit what she chose.

Additional Theoretical Deployments

Dick quotes the Framework constantly, applying its analysis of structural violence to American capitalism, arguing that the "structural violence" of inequality justifies "counter-violence" in the form of property destruction and disruption. He speaks of "decolonizing" everything—Thanksgiving, education, healthcare, even personal relationships.

When challenged on PILF's lack of concrete achievements, he invokes the Framework's fifth principle: "Process IS praxis. The system measures success by its own metrics, which are designed to reproduce the system. We refuse those metrics. Our work is building consciousness, creating space for liberation." This rhetorical move transforms organizational failure into revolutionary virtue.

But his core framework—the one he returns to again and again, the one that animates his understanding of the work—is collectivism vs. individualism, warm embrace vs. cold atomization, Sparta vs. Athens (though he would never use those terms, and wouldn't understand the parallel if it was pointed out).

What Dick Believes

Dick genuinely believes in the warm embrace. He's not cynical. He really thinks collectivism is liberation, individual rights are bourgeois ideology, submission to the collective is freedom, his organization represents the collective will, the discomfort of those being "embraced" is temporary resistance to their own liberation, and once they stop struggling, they'll feel relief.

He cannot see that he IS the collective he's demanding submission to, that his trust fund makes his collectivism costless, that his "warm embrace" feels very different to those being embraced, that he's building Sparta while calling it liberation, that the relief he promises is the relief of surrender.

This is why his fall is tragic rather than just pathetic. He believed. He genuinely thought he was building the warm embrace. He never understood he was building the closing trap.

The Fragile Ego

Dick is full of self-doubt about his own abilities. The serial seduction of leftist women isn't merely about conquest—it's about shoring up a fragile ego that his family systematically undermined. Each woman who falls for his Bildersatzian performance proves (temporarily) that he's desirable, powerful, worthy of attention.

Name Significance

The name is deliberately self-revealing in ways the character cannot perceive. "Dick" carries obvious connotations, while "Suede" evokes luxury, softness, the texture of wealth worn casually. He is, quite literally, a soft touch with a name that announces what everyone but him can see.

The Wardrobe: Bespoke Revolutionary

Dick has evolved past the college Che Guevara t-shirt into sophisticated radical chic—bespoke revolutionary fashion that costs even more while performing even harder. He now dresses like a

Brooklyn creative director cosplaying as a community organizer, a carefully constructed "I care about ethical consumption" aesthetic that actually requires more money and cultural capital than simply buying expensive suits.

The pieces: Selvedge denim from Japanese heritage brands ($300-400 jeans worn to look "authentically working-class"). Minimalist sneakers—Common Projects, Veja, or Allbirds ($250-400) marketed as "ethical sustainable footwear." Vintage band t-shirts—curated from specialty shops, not thrift stores ($80-150 each): Clash, Fugazi, Dead Kennedys. Tailored workwear jackets—Engineered Garments, RRL, Kapital ($400-800) "inspired by union organizing." Artisanal accessories—leather goods from "collective workshops," handwoven scarves from "cooperative weavers" (always expensive, always ethically sourced, always badges of taste). Wire-frame glasses—Warby Parker or similar, intellectual but accessible. Canvas tote bags—from progressive bookstores and NPR (free, but a curated collection). The occasional keffiyeh—worn as scarf, purchased from "fair trade Palestinian collective" ($60-100).

The hair: Grown out and product-free (but regularly trimmed at an expensive barber), the carefully maintained "I don't care" look that requires professional maintenance to appear effortlessly casual.

What he says about his clothes: "These jeans are from a worker-owned factory in Okayama." "I only buy vintage to avoid fast fashion exploitation." "My jacket is deadstock from a union warehouse." "These sneakers are made from recycled ocean plastic."

What his clothes actually signal: Access to specialty markets that require cultural capital to navigate. Time to curate vintage finds (or money to buy pre-curated vintage). Disposable income to spend $400 on "ethical" sneakers. A refined aesthetic sensibility that requires expensive taste education.

The total outfit costs $1,500-2,000. He's not wearing a costume anymore; he's wearing a curated identity that signals sophisticated anti-capitalism through expensive taste. Each piece is "ethically sourced," "supports cooperatives," or has "historical labor significance"—and each piece costs more than an actual worker would spend on an entire month's wardrobe.

The TWEEEDS connection he never makes: The fabrics—heritage wool, artisanal denim, vintage workwear materials—echo the visual language of TWEEEDS. He's wearing tweed-adjacent materials, performing working-class solidarity through the aesthetic signifiers of old-money prep school culture. The irony is invisible to him.

The aesthetic evolution: College Dick wore an actual Che Guevara t-shirt, army surplus jacket, combat boots—visible performance of revolution. Current Dick looks like someone who could be a creative director at a progressive ad agency, a senior staffer at a foundation, an NPR podcast host, a visiting fellow at a think tank. Which is to say: he looks like someone who talks about the working class rather than someone who is working class.

His wardrobe performs solidarity with labor while demonstrating distance from it. Every "union-made" piece costs more than an actual union worker would spend. He dresses like a museum exhibit of working-class authenticity, curating an identity that requires never having to budget like the people he claims to represent.

The psychological tell: Dick has convinced himself his wardrobe is anti-capitalist because he avoids fast fashion (exploitation), buys vintage (sustainability), supports worker cooperatives (solidarity), and invests in quality pieces (anti-consumerism). He cannot see that his anti-capitalism requires more capital than capitalism. His rejection of the market requires sophisticated market knowledge. His solidarity with workers requires never having to budget like a worker.

The cognitive dissonance is perfect: he's dressed for the revolution in clothes the revolution can't afford.

The Loyal Supporter

Dick has been a loyal supporter of Pengold and TWEEEDS, repeatedly donating money and lending his organization's credibility to Pengold's initiatives. He has been promised the GRIFT grant—the Grassroots Resilience and Innovation Fund for Transformation—that will pull PILF out of its immediate crisis.

Dick is naive about Pengold's capacity for treachery. He genuinely believes that his loyalty will be rewarded, that Pengold is an ally in the struggle, that the progressive community protects its own. He does not understand that he has already been selected as the sacrifice—that Pengold has been positioning him for destruction while accepting his donations and promising his grant.

Role in the Triangle

How They Met

Four years ago, Dick attended Pengold's first city council campaign victory party. Summer was running the event—the brilliant strategist who just won an impossible race. Dick was young, newer to activism, impressionable. He approached Summer, starstruck. She was gracious but professional, running the party. They talked briefly. He made an impression—earnest, passionate, attractive in an unthreatening way. She barely remembered him; he remembered her vividly. (That same night, later, Summer and Pengold had their drunken encounter that she immediately regretted—the unspoken thing between them ever since.)

Three years later, after Summer's marriage was deteriorating, Philip published his critique of NGO activism. PILF (Dick's now-more-established organization) organized the protest campaign that drove him from his position. Summer didn't attend the protests but watched from a distance—both horrified and fascinated.

Two years ago, Summer's divorce was finalized (one year ago from the opera's present). She ran into Dick at a coalition meeting. He reminded her they met on election night. She was surprised he remembered. They talked Bildersatz—he quoted the Framework's principles on collective awakening, she countered with passages on structural harm. The conversation was electric, Bildersatzian sparring as foreplay.

He mentioned PILF's recent campaign work casually, proud of their success targeting that professor. Summer realized: "Wait, what professor?" And he told her. And she understood what had happened. And she said nothing about the connection.

Or maybe she already knew—suspected from the beginning—and pursued the relationship anyway. Maybe being with the man who destroyed her ex-husband was part of the attraction. Punishment? Erasure? Moving on by moving forward?

They started collaborating professionally. Coffee became drinks became dinner. She was attracted to his passion, his certainty, his youth. He was attracted to her experience, her intelligence, her established credibility.

The Relationship

By the opera's Thanksgiving week, the affair is 1-2 years old. Long enough to be serious. Recent enough to still be passionate. Old enough that they've settled into patterns.

Dick, in spite of himself and his long rolodex of conquests, has genuinely fallen for Summer. This is not another seduction, not another credential. He is charmed by her physical beauty, her encyclopedic knowledge of the Framework, her devout fervor to the cause. She is everything he performs but fears he isn't.

Why Dick Loves Summer: She's beautiful (he's shallow, she's genuinely attractive). She's brilliant (her Bildersatzian fluency impresses him). She's successful (LYSTERIA is established, she has real credibility). She's his social equal (old money, blue blood, not a grad student he's slumming with). She's potentially useful (her connection to Pengold could protect PILF). She's a challenge (she's not immediately available, she has actual power). She takes him seriously as a revolutionary—doesn't condescend, doesn't see "Little Dickie," sees the person he wants to be.

He's in love with her vision of him. That's why losing her approval—her watching his arrest without defending him—will be so destroying.

Why Summer Loves Dick

Summer's feelings are more complex and more genuine than she wants to admit:

Validation of Her Choices: Dick is younger, attractive, completely committed to the movement. He thinks her sterilization was brave, not pathological. He quotes the same Bildersatz passages she does. He sees her work as revolutionary, not performative. He never asks "What won't you do for the cause?" because he believes there should be no limits.

The Revolutionary Romance She Always Wanted: Philip wanted conventional domesticity. Dick offers partnership in the struggle—they're comrades first, lovers second. Their relationship IS political praxis (or so she tells herself). The polyamory proposition is theoretically sophisticated, not an affair.

Physical Attraction Without Compromise: Dick is genuinely attractive, charismatic, passionate. The sex is good (he's had lots of practice). She doesn't have to choose between desire and the movement. Unlike Pengold (calculating, patient, strategic), Dick is present.

He Makes Her Feel Young Again: Summer is established, ten years running LYSTERIA. Dick is newer to organizing, eager, impressed by her. He treats her like a revolutionary elder worth learning from. Being desired by him makes her feel like she's still in the vanguard, not becoming part of the establishment.

He Never Questions Her: Philip questioned everything. Pengold questions strategically (what serves the machine?). Dick believes—purely, completely, naively. Being with him means not having to defend herself or examine contradictions.

The Warm Embrace: This is the deepest reason, the one Summer barely admits to herself. Philip offered cold analysis—Sparta vs. Athens, Thucydides' warnings, historical parallels, uncomfortable questions. Dick offers the warm embrace—the promise that collective care will solve everything, that submission to the movement is liberation, that she doesn't have to stand alone in her doubts.

Philip said: "The warm embrace closes like a fist." Dick says: "The warm embrace is relief from the burden of individualism." Summer chose the warm embrace. She rejected the cold analysis. Being with Dick means never having to hear Philip's voice in her head asking whether the collective she's building requires submission rather than cooperation.

Dick validates the choice she made to leave her marriage. He embodies the alternative to Philip's cold skepticism. He is living proof that the warm embrace exists, that collective liberation is possible, that Philip was wrong.

Except now she's trapped in the closing fist and cannot admit what she chose.

The Tragedy: Summer loves Dick because he believes all the things she's no longer sure she believes. He performs the revolutionary she wishes she still was. Watching him is like watching her younger self—before the compromises, before the grant cycles, before the strategic ambiguity with Pengold.

She loves him for his naivety. And then she destroys him for it.

When she watches Dick arrested, when she stays silent while Pengold's trap closes around him, she is watching the warm embrace close like a fist—exactly as Philip warned. And she cannot save Dick without admitting Philip was right.

The Asymmetry

Somewhere in Act II, Dick and Summer discuss "their" first meeting. He remembers it fondly—the election night, the early encounter. He romanticizes it: "I knew that night you were someone special."

She remembers it differently, or doesn't remember it at all. "I met so many people that night."

He's hurt—the moment that changed his trajectory barely registered for her. But he recovers: "Well, I remembered you. That's what matters."

The asymmetry of their relationship is established. He loves the idea of them as revolutionary partners, destined to meet, meant to build something together. She loves the convenience of someone who believes in her completely and never asks hard questions.

This makes her betrayal of him even more devastating: He thought they had a grand romance. She had a convenient affair that didn't interfere with her actual ambitions.

But Summer represents something else as well: she has the class bona fides that Dick secretly craves. Unlike his other conquests—graduate students, NGO staffers, activist volunteers—Summer comes from an affluent, blue-blood New England family. She is a suitable match for him socially, a limousine liberal with revolutionary trappings, his equal in the performance of radicalism from positions of inherited privilege.

And perhaps subconsciously, he believes her connection to Pengold would cement the survival of PILF. If Summer loves him, Pengold will have to protect him. The woman and the funding become intertwined in his mind—not cynically, but in the desperate logic of someone whose organization is failing and whose identity depends on its success.

His competition with Pengold is partly about Summer, partly ego—he's used to being the most desired radical in the room. But his feelings for Summer are real. That's what makes his fate tragic rather than merely pathetic.

The Fall

Dick's arrest at the Anti-Thanksgiving Feast is the opera's climactic action. He is led away in chains while the assembled activists watch in horror. The charges: misappropriation of public funds, fraud, grant violations. Everything they all do, but only Dick will pay for.

His final moment on stage should be genuine pathos despite everything. "Little Dickie" finally made his mark—as the designated villain. His family was right about him, but not in the way they thought. He wasn't too soft to succeed; he was too naive to survive.

The Suicide

After Dick is taken away, unable to face the public exposure, the federal charges, the collapse of everything he built to escape being "Little Dickie," he takes his own life. The trust fund revolutionary who wanted to make his mark independent of his family has made his final mark: a cautionary tale, a scapegoat, a body.

Throughout the opera, Dick has asked: "Is ANY of it real?" In the end, his death is real. The shame is real. The consequences are real. The performance finally collided with material reality, and material reality won.

Valencia Strong

Actual Working-Class Organizer / Omniscient Observer / Greek Chorus

Voice Type: Mezzo-soprano

Structural Function

Valencia serves as the opera's Greek chorus of one, commenting on the action while remaining invisible to the principal characters. She alone addresses economic reality, material conditions, and the class dynamics that the other characters systematically avoid.

Her arias punctuate the drama with observations the others cannot hear and truths they cannot speak. She is the only character who knows she's in a satire while everyone else plays it as sincere drama. She provides historical context, translates revolutionary rhetoric, and comments on the action.

Character Position

Valencia is a recent member of PILF who joined believing in the organization's original mission—economic justice, material conditions, the actual bread-and-butter work that the opera's other characters systematically avoid. She read PILF's founding documents, felt energized by their stated commitment to working-class struggle, and took the job. She is not an idealist in the abstract sense; she understands economics concretely, which is precisely why the original mission appealed to her. She did not join a movement. She joined what looked like a serious organization doing serious economic work.

The awakening is not a single revelation but a slow, uncomfortable accumulation. She starts seeing the gap between the mission statement and the actual activity: grant money flowing toward awareness campaigns instead of material support, the rhetoric of solidarity with none of the structural work, the shakedown campaigns reframed as activism. Each realization is quiet—a number here, a meeting there, a conversation that does not add up. She is not discovering that PILF is evil. She is discovering that the organization she believed in has drifted, and nobody around her seems to notice or care.

Valencia believes, at least initially, that she can steer PILF back to its original mission from the inside. She thinks if she can get the right people in the right room, redirect the funding, remind everyone what the work was supposed to be, the organization can be saved. This is its own quiet tragedy, because the audience can see what she cannot yet fully accept: that the drift is not a corruption of PILF. It is PILF now.

And she needs the job. Every time she thinks about walking out or speaking up, the rent is due. She is the only character in the opera whose economic constraints are real and immediate—which is dramatically precise, because she is the one who sings about economics. She lives it while everyone else performs around it. Sartre's waiter in Being and Nothingness chose his role and could theoretically choose otherwise; Valencia's constraint is genuine. Dick and Summer have the freedom to be honest and will not use it. Valencia has the clarity to be honest and cannot afford to. That contrast is devastating, and it is completely silent.

Her hands remain clean: she has not participated in the shakedowns, has not endorsed the targeting. But she is inside the machine, and the machine runs on her silence. She is the opera's compact with the

audience: I know this is absurd. You know this is absurd. I am going to show you exactly how absurd it is, and exactly why I am still standing in it, and you are going to understand both things at once.

Name Significance

Valencia suggests both the Spanish city (with its history of trade and commerce) and the Latin root "valere" (to be strong, to have worth—the root of "value" itself). Strong reinforces this: she represents the strength of economic reality that persists regardless of what ideological frameworks people use to describe it.

The Final Aria

Valencia's final aria is the opera's emotional and thematic culmination. It begins as reflection on the evening's events, on the cycle of grift and sacrifice, on the machine that consumes its own. But midway through, she receives word: Dick Suede is dead.

Her aria shifts. The musical language changes—perhaps those blues and work song references emerge most fully here. She sings of what remains when the ideologies fade: the work that must still be done, the bills that must still be paid, the bodies that must be buried, the questions that must be answered.

Valencia saw through Dick's performance, but she also saw the wounded person beneath it. Her aria acknowledges both: the trust fund revolutionary who never examined his privilege, AND the human being destroyed by forces larger than himself.

She does not tell Summer what to do. She simply asks, in music, the question the audience must carry home: "What won't you do?"

IV. THE FEDERAL INVESTIGATION

The Opening

The opera opens with Mayor Pengold Heavens alone in his office, reading headlines about federal investigators circling New Harnomy's NGO ecosystem. This is his calculating moment: who can be sacrificed to make this go away? The audience sees immediately what Dick Suede cannot—the man he has been loyally supporting is already measuring him for the altar.

The federal investigation threatens to expose what everyone in New Harnomy's progressive community knows but never acknowledges: the entire NGO ecosystem runs on mutual complicity and willful blindness. Everyone's books are problematic. Everyone has been playing fast and loose with grant requirements. The system functions through patronage, not programs.

The Systemic Grift

PILF's gross mismanagement is not unique—it's endemic to New Harnomy's NGO landscape. Grant funds are allocated according to whim rather than program requirements. Reporting is creative at best, fraudulent at worst. Outcomes are manufactured, metrics massaged, impact statements written before programs launch.

The progressive community has operated this way for years, protected by ideological solidarity and the assumption that no one would investigate organizations doing "good work." But federal oversight has finally arrived, and someone must take the fall.

Pengold's Calculation

Pengold's solution is elegant in its ruthlessness: sacrifice Dick Suede. The trust fund revolutionary is perfect for the role—easy to paint as a dilettante who got in over his head, whose organization's failures can be attributed to incompetence rather than systemic corruption. Throwing Dick to the federal investigators accomplishes multiple goals simultaneously.

First, it placates federal oversight by offering a contained scandal: look, we found the problem and dealt with it. Second, it protects the broader system by providing a scapegoat whose individual failure obscures collective corruption. Third, it removes a romantic rival for Summer's attention. Fourth, it demonstrates Pengold's "commitment to accountability" while preserving the machine he operates.

The summer intern who learned how power works now wields it against the trust fund kid who never had to learn anything.

V. ORGANIZATIONAL LANDSCAPE

The Acronym Ecology

The opera features a carefully constructed ecosystem of organizations whose acronyms are self-revealing in ways their founders cannot perceive. Each name follows the Wildean principle: the characters believe these names to be powerful and dignified, blind to what they actually communicate.

LYSTERIA Coalition for Reproductive Justice

Summer's established organization. The name is an ambiguous portmanteau that could evoke Lysistrata (Greek play about women's reproductive power), Hysteria (gendered medical dismissal of women), Listeria (bacteria associated with pregnancy risks), or generic official-sounding NGO-speak. Nobody really knows what it means; everyone nods along.

The organization does legitimate work: abortion access, contraception, STI testing, real services. It is well-funded and respected in the community after a decade of genuine track record. This legitimacy is what makes it valuable as an umbrella for newer initiatives—and what's now at stake.

The Man Bun Collective

Summer's new initiative under LYSTERIA, created specifically to qualify for the federal gender-affirming healthcare grant. The name captures the performative masculinity that has become fashionable in certain progressive circles—a hairstyle that signals sensitivity while remaining firmly within male privilege.

The Collective focuses on trans masculine gestational care and fertility preservation for people assigned male at birth. Zero services provided so far, mostly branding and planning. The New Harnomy People's Thanksgiving Festival is its official launch event.

The People's Intersectional Liberation Front (PILF)

Dick Suede's organization, founded secretly with trust fund money. The acronym references vulgar slang that Dick cannot hear. The organization claims revolutionary politics while operating on city grants and Dick's inheritance.

PILF's stated mission is "community liberation through intersectional resistance." Programs include: a weekly reading group studying the Framework; poorly attended "know your rights" trainings; mutual aid distribution funded by trust fund and grants; direct action planning meetings; and "decolonization workshops" for other NGOs. The gap between revolutionary rhetoric and actual impact is vast.

The organization has been grossly mismanaged, its books a disaster, its grant compliance nonexistent. When federal investigators come looking for a scapegoat, PILF's failures will be presented as individual incompetence rather than systemic corruption.

PILF's most visible activity ahead of the Thanksgiving rally is a "donation" campaign—a shakedown of local small businesses, religious institutions, and one particularly inconvenient academic, conducted under the banner of community solidarity and framed as support for the rally. The targets are presented as agents of social oppression; the reality is considerably smaller and more defenseless. Valencia Strong recently joined believing in the organization's original economic justice mission and is beginning to understand what it has actually become.

TWEEEDS (Toward Workers' Emancipation, Equity, and Empowerment of Democratic Socialists)

Pengold's political party. Always spelled with three E's, pronounced "Tweeds" (like the fabric). The naming was entirely accidental—earnestly workshopped in committee, no one knows who Boss Tweed was or makes the connection.

Triple irony: named after Boss Tweed (William M. Tweed, epitome of political corruption and patronage networks); evokes tweed fabric (prep school, Ivy League, old money aesthetic); and exemplifies the alphabet soup of contemporary NGO/political naming.

The GRIFT Grant

The Grassroots Resilience and Innovation Fund for Transformation—the city grant that Pengold has promised Dick Suede, the grant that would save PILF from insolvency, the grant that will never arrive. The acronym tells the truth that no one can hear.

VI. SETTING AND TIMEFRAME

New Harnomy

The fictional city of New Harnomy deliberately echoes New Harmony, Indiana—Robert Owen's failed utopian community of the 1820s. The misspelling embeds harm within harmony: the town believes it's building "New Harmony" but creates new harm—new forms of harm disguised as harmony.

American utopian projects have always collapsed into factional infighting and bourgeois pretension. The name itself is the thesis statement. No character ever acknowledges the spelling—to them it's simply "New Harmony," pronounced normally. The audience sees what the characters cannot.

New Harnomy represents a factionalized American city where ideological purity tests determine social standing and performative activism has replaced actual governance.

Thanksgiving Week

The opera unfolds during Thanksgiving week, a choice laden with irony. The holiday celebrates national unity, family gathering, and gratitude—while commemorating a moment of colonial encounter that would lead to genocide. The holiday of abundance, gratitude, and giving is ironically juxtaposed with the barrenness and grift of New Harnomy's revolutionary performance.

For the characters, Thanksgiving creates deadline pressure: Summer's federal grant application is due right after the holiday. The charitable giving season represents peak NGO performance.

The New Harnomy People's Thanksgiving Festival

The central event driving the action: a week-long city-sponsored "alternative Thanksgiving" festival leading up to an Anti-Thanksgiving Day culmination.

Officially sponsored by Mayor Pengold's TWEEEDS administration, co-organized by PILF (Dick Suede) and The Man Bun Collective (Summer Winters), and funded by city grants—the patronage machine in action. Marketed as "Decolonizing gratitude, centering marginalized voices, reimagining abundance."

The festival forces constant interaction, creates natural escalation, and serves as the perfect vehicle for themes: performing anti-colonialism while practicing patronage colonialism, exposing mythology while enacting their own. The workers they claim to represent are serving them at their events.

Staging Note: The Mauve Books Throughout

Throughout the opera, copies of the Framework should be visible on stage. In offices, they line shelves. At the festival, they appear on display tables. Characters carry them, reference them, gesture toward them. All copies are mauve—the distinctive color has become synonymous with Bildersatzian consciousness itself. The audience sees the same mauve books in every location, carried by every character—a shared theoretical vocabulary that unites this community even as it fragments over personal and political conflicts.

The Three Acts

Act One ("The Gathering"): Monday through Wednesday before Thanksgiving. The opera opens with Pengold reading headlines about federal investigations, already calculating his sacrifice. The festival begins with land acknowledgment ceremonies, workshops, fundraising galas. The romantic triangle forms. Dick, naive and hopeful, awaits his promised GRIFT grant. Summer begins her affair with Dick while negotiating matching funds with Pengold.

Act Two ("The Crisis"): Thursday and Friday. Tensions escalate. Summer learns of Pengold's plot to sacrifice Dick but remains silent to protect her funding. The funding scandal begins to break. Dick remains oblivious, still believing Pengold will protect him. The love triangle intensifies against the backdrop of impending betrayal.

Act Three ("The Reckoning"): Saturday—Anti-Thanksgiving Day. The climactic Anti-Thanksgiving Feast becomes the site of Dick's arrest. He is led away in chains. Summer watches, having chosen silence. Pengold confirms her matching funds. Then news arrives: Dick has taken his own life. Valencia's final aria. Summer's face. The unresolved chord. Blackout.

VII. MUSICAL STRUCTURE

Scale and Duration

The opera comprises 48 musical numbers across three acts, with a total running time of approximately three hours including two intermissions.

Cast: 3 principals (Soprano, Tenor, Baritone) + Valencia (Mezzo-soprano, narrator) + ensemble.

Musical Language

The score inverts the conventions of Maoist model operas. Where those works used Western orchestration to present revolutionary content with apparent sincerity, New Harnomy uses sophisticated contemporary techniques to present progressive content whose contradictions become increasingly apparent.

The musical language should feel both earnest and slightly off—beautiful surfaces that don't quite resolve, harmonic progressions that promise satisfaction but deliver something slightly different. The music mirrors the characters' condition: genuine emotion expressed through frameworks that cannot contain it.

Valencia's Idiom

Valencia's musical material stands apart from the other characters. While they sing in idioms appropriate to their self-presentation—Summer's soaring idealism, Pengold's measured authority, Dick's revolutionary fervor—Valencia employs a more direct, economically precise musical language.

Her arias may reference older traditions (blues, work songs, the musical language of actual labor) while remaining contemporary. She represents a form of knowledge that predates and will outlast the ideological fashions the other characters inhabit.

The Cellist's Fragment

A single musical fragment—a short phrase in Valencia's modal idiom—is seeded before the opera begins and returns only in her final aria. The audience hears it first during the lobby hour: a cellist warming up in the pit plays it, apparently noodling, over and over, woven in among scales and tuning. The audience registers it unconsciously. Three hours later, when Valencia sings it, the phrase will feel both new and inevitable—the only thing in the evening the listener has actually been prepared for.

No character in the opera ever hears the cellist. Valencia's melody predates New Harnomy. That is the point.

The Unresolved Chord

The opera ends on an unresolved chord—the musical equivalent of Summer's unmade choice. The audience leaves with dissonance in their ears, the question hanging in the air. There is no catharsis, no resolution. The chord is the sound of moral compromise that never quite resolves into either courage or capitulation.

The chord is not a triad. It contains both the TWEEEDS theme's triumphant major and Valencia's modal minor simultaneously, so the ear cannot decide which key the opera has been in. It is not faded. It is severed. The silence that follows is the work.

VIII. THEMATIC ARCHITECTURE

The Central Theme: Authenticity vs. Performance

The impossibility of authentic revolution under conditions of inauthenticity. Or: "You Cannot Perform Your Way to Liberation." Revolutionary rhetoric masks bourgeois emotional chaos and class privilege. The "revolution" is a personal brand, activism is a career path, and resistance has been professionalized.

The Question

"What won't you do for the cause?" This question, first posed by Summer's ex-husband, haunts the entire opera. Each principal character answers it through their actions. Pengold will sacrifice anyone. Dick will perform anything. And Summer—Summer will let a man die.

The question passes to the audience in Valencia's final aria. The opera refuses to answer it for them. They must carry it home, must sit with it, must ask themselves what they would do in Summer's position. Most of them, if they're honest, don't know.

The Monopoly on Truth

Pengold embodies a particular progressive pathology: the belief that he and his followers have a monopoly on Truth, and that left to their own devices, the population would make the wrong choices for their own well-being. This paternalism cloaks itself in liberatory language while practicing the mechanics of control.

The Absent Economic

The opera's central structural device is the systematic absence of economic discussion among the principal characters. They speak constantly of justice, liberation, identity, and love—but never of money, class, labor, or ownership. Valencia alone can speak of economics, and she remains unheard.

The Selective Blindness

The characters know history—but only certain histories. They can recite the crimes of colonialism, capitalism, and American empire. They are willfully blind to the crimes committed in liberation's name: the Soviet gulags, the Cambodian killing fields, the Cuban political prisons, the Chinese Cultural Revolution. Revolutionary movements that became vehicles for new forms of terror are absent from their theoretical library.

This selective blindness is not ignorance but ideology. Acknowledging that liberation movements can produce new forms of domination would require examining their own positions within the movements they lead. The theoretical frameworks that illuminate oppression elsewhere become tools for concealing it at home.

The Cycle Continues

The "revolution" changes nothing fundamental. Dick's sacrifice protects the system. Summer's silence preserves her position. Pengold's machine continues. The ending isn't triumphant or defeated—it's cyclical, which is perhaps most tragic of all.

Year-end becomes new year planning. Same grift, new season. New federal grants to chase. New sacrifices to be selected. The only question is who will be next.

IX. STRUCTURAL INVERSION

Traditional Model Opera vs. New Harnomy, USA

The opera systematically inverts every element of the Maoist model opera form:

Where model operas depicted real material oppression (starvation, violence, exploitation), New Harnomy depicts imagined symbolic oppression (hurt feelings, insufficient validation). Where workers and peasants genuinely suffered, credentialed elites claim victimhood. Where clear external villains existed (landlords, imperialists), enemies here are abstractions or each other.

Where heroes gained consciousness through Party teachings, here "consciousness" is performed for career advancement. Where personal grievance led to collective struggle, collective rhetoric leads to personal careerism. Where unity formed against class enemies, fragmentation occurs through purity tests. Where self-sacrifice served revolution, self-promotion is revolution.

Where trials meant imprisonment, torture, possible death, trials here mean being called out and feeling bad. Where strategy came from Mao's military tactics, strategy here means grant-writing and networking. Where decisive battle defeated villains, here the love triangle collapses and patronage is exposed.

Where revolutionary order was established, "revolutionary order" here means rebranding the grift. Where new society emerged under Party leadership, the same society continues with new slogans. Where fallen martyrs were honored, cancelled friends are briefly mourned then forgotten.

Where triumphant unified finales extolled Mao, here cacophonous competing visions offer no resolution. Where collective heroes emerged, individual careerists persist. Where clear tonal resolution occurred, an unresolved musical chord lingers. Where audiences were inspired to join the struggle, audiences here recognize the con.

Where spring, harvest, and abundance imagery prevailed, winter, barrenness, and scarcity dominate (Summer Winters, Thanksgiving week).

X. THE ENDING

The Speech: Celebration to Denunciation

The Anti-Thanksgiving Feast reaches its climax with Mayor Pengold Heavens taking the stage to deliver the evening's keynote address. He begins with celebration—announcing the city's signature investment in progressive healthcare, the $5 million matching funds that will unlock $50 million in federal support for the Man Bun Collective's vital work in gender-affirming reproductive care.

As Pengold speaks Summer's name with reverence, a massive Socialist Realist-inspired portrait of Summer Winters begins to rise behind him—heroic, idealized, bathed in golden light. She is depicted as the embodiment of revolutionary care, a mother of the movement despite her barrenness, gazing toward an undefined but glorious future.

Then Pengold's tone shifts. The pivot is seamless, almost imperceptible at first—the practiced maneuver of a machine politician who learned by watching. He speaks of accountability. Of protecting the movement from those who would exploit it. Of the sacred trust of public funds. The celebration curdles into denunciation.

He names Dick Suede. He names PILF. He speaks of "disturbing irregularities" discovered through the city's "commitment to transparency." The language is Maoist in its structure—the confession of sins against the collective, the identification of counter-revolutionary elements, the purge disguised as purification.

The Arrest

The City AG enters with officers as Pengold concludes. Dick Suede is seized. He is led away in chains—literally shackled—while the assembled activists watch in horror.

Dick protests his innocence. He calls out to Pengold—his friend, his ally, the man whose campaigns he funded, whose party he supported, whose promises he believed. "Pengold! Tell them! You know me! You know PILF's work!" But Pengold does not look at him.

Above the stage, Summer's portrait continues to glow in socialist splendor. Below it, Dick is dragged toward the exit, still proclaiming his innocence to a room that has already convicted him. The visual is unmistakable: one rises as the other falls. Summer's ascension requires Dick's destruction.

Dick's final moment on stage is genuine pathos despite everything. "Little Dickie" finally made his mark—as the designated villain in someone else's revolutionary theater.

Summer Beneath Her Portrait

Throughout the speech and arrest, Summer stands frozen beneath her own glorified image. The portrait shows her as she wishes to be seen—heroic, certain, righteous. Her actual face tells another story: the recognition, the horror, the knowledge that she chose this.

She learned of the plot surreptitiously and remained silent. She had time to warn Dick. She calculated the cost and found his life worth less than her federal grant. Now she watches the man she could have saved being led away to his destruction, while her idealized face beams down from above.

Pengold looks at her—just for an instant—making sure she sees, making sure she understands: I did this. I can do it to anyone. I chose to protect you. Remember that. The portrait and the threat are one gesture.

The Mafia Wife Coronation

The final tableau is not merely Summer watching Dick be taken away. It is her initiation as a "made" woman in Pengold's machine. The room clears. Dick has been led out. The chorus is frozen. And Pengold walks—unhurried, processional—to Summer beneath her glowing portrait, and places his right hand on her left shoulder.

This is the counter-sacrament. In a work where the mauve Framework is the Eucharist, the touch is the confirmation. She does not move. She does not look at him. She looks out, past the house, at nothing.

Pengold's face in this moment is the casting test. Not triumph, not smugness—settled. The face of a man for whom a long-running problem has been resolved, and who knows better than to celebrate visibly because the machine frowns on visible celebration. The smallest possible smile. Held.

The visual completes what "They, the People" began: Pengold has loved the people into dependence, and now he loves Summer into the machine. She has traded individual conscience—which the Framework's seventh principle calls "false consciousness"—for the $50 million federal grant. She will tell herself later that this is what revolution costs. She will tell herself many things. But the hand on her shoulder is the fact beneath the rationalization.

She is now a "made" woman. The embrace has closed like a fist. And Philip—driven from his post a year before for warning that this would happen—is not there to see it.

The Confirmation

As Pengold's hand rests on her shoulder, his first words are not about Dick—they are about her matching funds. "LYSTERIA's allocation is confirmed. The federal application can proceed. Your work will continue." The quid pro quo is unspoken but unmistakable. Dick's destruction purchased her survival. Her portrait's ascension was paid for in his chains.

The Suicide

The stage clears. Valencia remains. She begins her final aria. Midway through, she receives word: Dick Suede is dead. Unable to face the public exposure, the federal charges, the collapse of everything he built to escape being "Little Dickie," he has taken his own life.

The trust fund revolutionary who wanted to make his mark independent of his family has made his final mark: a cautionary tale, a scapegoat, a body.

Valencia's Final Aria

Valencia's aria shifts after the news of Dick's death. She sings of what remains when the ideologies fade: the work that must still be done, the bills that must still be paid, the bodies that must be buried, the questions that must be answered.

She does not tell Summer what to do. She simply asks, in music, the question the audience must carry home: "What won't you do?"

The Six Beats of the Finale

The final ninety seconds of the opera resolve into six precise beats, each with its own musical, visual, and dramatic logic. This is the staging blueprint against which all directorial choices in the closing sequence must be measured.

Beat 1 — The Denunciation (0–15 seconds)

Full stage, full chorus, full orchestra. The TWEEEDS theme in its most triumphant orchestration, brass forward. Dick has just been seized by the City AG. He is downstage center, being led in chains toward the

stage-left exit. The chorus is in formation behind Pengold, mauve books raised in unison the way congregants raise hymnals. Summer's portrait is at half-height and rising, lit from below in Socialist-Realist gold.

Beat 2 — The Listening (15–35 seconds)

The orchestra thins. Not stops—thins. Strings drop out. Brass drops out. What remains is a single clarinet holding the TWEEEDS melody, and Dick's voice over it, clear, unamplified, human:

"Pengold—you know me. You know the work. Tell them."

The chorus does not hear him. Pengold does not turn. Summer's portrait reaches its apex and holds, blazing. Dick's voice is perfectly audible to the audience and perfectly inaudible to everyone on stage. He is not drowned out. He is ignored. That is the harder satire. That is the closing fist in its operational form.

Beat 3 — The Exit (35–50 seconds)

Dick is led off. He does not scream. He stops speaking at the threshold, turns once, and looks—not at Pengold, not at Summer—at Valencia, who is upstage right, holding a mauve book she has not opened. The only moment of genuine seeing in the opera. Valencia holds his look. The clarinet sustains. Dick exits. The clarinet stops mid-phrase.

Beat 4 — The Coronation (50–65 seconds)

Silence on stage. Pengold turns from the podium and walks—unhurried, processional—to Summer. The portrait above her blazes. He places his right hand on her left shoulder. She does not move. She does not look at him. She looks out, past the house, at nothing. This is the Mafia Wife Coronation. The smallest possible smile on Pengold's face. Held.

Beat 5 — Valencia (65–80 seconds)

One step downstage from upstage right. Into her own light. She opens the mauve book she has been holding. She looks at it. She closes it. She lets it fall from her hand—not dramatically, just lets it fall. It hits the floor with a single unamplified thump. She sings one line:

"What won't you do?"

Not accusatory. Quiet. A question, offered to the house.

Beat 6 — The Chord and the Cut (80–90 seconds)

The orchestra enters underneath her—not a crescendo, an accumulation. Every instrument, one by one, joining on a single sustained chord. Not a triad. Something that contains both the TWEEEDS major and Valencia's modal minor inside it, so the ear cannot decide what key it is in. The chord grows until it is almost unbearable.

The stage picture is locked: Pengold's hand on Summer's shoulder. Portrait blazing above them. Valencia in her own light, the dropped mauve book at her feet. The chorus frozen mid-gesture, books still raised. Nobody breathing.

Hard cut to black. No fade. The chord does not resolve; it is severed. The silence that follows is the work.

Hold the blackout eight seconds before any house light rises. Eight seconds is cruel. Eight seconds is correct.

The Ambiguous Ending

The opera does not answer whether Summer will ever speak. The unresolved chord is the musical form of her unmade choice. She may, in the days after the feast, expose Pengold's machinations and sacrifice her career. She may remain silent, take the matching funds, let Dick's death purchase her federal grant. The opera refuses to say. Summer's face. The recognition. The weight. The choice unmade.

The Question for the Audience

The ambiguous ending refuses to let the audience off the hook. They don't get to feel superior to Summer because they never have to make her choice. They leave the theater asking themselves: what would I do?

Most audience members, in their daily lives, make smaller versions of Summer's choice constantly. They stay silent when they should speak. They accept benefits from systems they know are corrupt. They let others take falls that protect their own positions. Summer's frozen face is a mirror.

The opera closes, but the questions it raises continue—in the lobby, on the way home, in the conversations that follow.

A satire. A tragedy. A warning. A witness.

XI. PRODUCTION BLUEPRINT

The production extends the Wildean principle to the audience itself. No irony anywhere in the frame. The audience must be inside New Harnomy before the first note is played, and must remain inside it after the last note is severed. Three production elements outside the libretto itself enforce this: the Pre-Show Immersion, the First 90 Seconds, and the Curtain Call Problem.

These are not atmospheric flourishes. They are load-bearing. Without them, the opera can still be performed; it cannot be experienced as intended.

Pre-Show Immersion

The lobby is decorated as if this is the genuine world premiere of a sincere revolutionary opera. LYSTERIA Coalition information tables. Man Bun Collective QR codes for donations. A PILF volunteer asking if you'd like to sign a petition on your way in. The program book is printed in mauve and titled

A Framework for Progressive Awakening: Commemorative Edition, with a folded performance insert tucked inside. The house manager announces "please silence your phones in solidarity with our most vulnerable." A cellist warming up in the pit plays a fragment that the audience will not recognize until Valencia's final aria—by which time the fragment will have been seeded for three hours in their unconscious.

The audience walks into the satire before the curtain rises. Not one sign tells them so. Not one element of the lobby experience breaks character. The ushers are in period—professional-class progressive casual, Veja sneakers, tote bags from the local independent bookstore. The bar serves natural wine.

This is not comedy. This is the production's thesis in staging:

> *You did not come to watch. You came to attend.*

The First 90 Seconds

Houselights stay up ten seconds longer than they should. Long enough that people start looking around. Then they snap to black—hard cut, no dimmer—and for three full seconds there is nothing: no light, no music, no orchestra warming, no breathing. A cough from the house sounds like a gunshot.

A single cold wash comes up on the proscenium. Not the stage—the proscenium, lit from the house side, so the audience sees the ornament of the theater itself, the place they paid to sit in. Held four seconds.

Then the stage is revealed. One room. Pengold's mayoral office at dawn. Not grand—modest mid-century municipal, the kind of mahogany-laminate authority that aspires to rooms Robert Moses actually occupied. A desk. A lamp still on from the night before. A half-empty coffee cup. A folded newspaper. On the credenza behind him: three mauve books, stacked.

Pengold is already seated when the light finds him. He does not react to being seen. He is reading.

The audience watches him read for twenty-two seconds. Not pretend to read—actually read, silently, the full beat, page turn included. Twenty-two seconds is a very long time in a theater. Long enough for a laugh to flicker when nothing is said. Long enough for the laugh to die in confusion. Long enough for discomfort to set in. The audience is being taught, in real time, that this opera will not reassure them.

He sets the paper down carefully, aligned to the edge of the desk. He looks at the audience—not at us, past us, at the middle distance. He inhales to speak. Holds it. Exhales without having spoken.

Then the first bar of the orchestra: a single bass note. Low. Held.

And over that held note, Pengold's recitative begins—not to us, not to himself, but to the federal investigation he can feel circling the building:

> *"Who among them / can I afford to lose?"*

Blackout on him. Houselights come up on the audience as the chorus streams in from the vomitoria around the house, already singing "Competing Anthems of Victimhood." The audience is now surrounded. The opera has not started on stage; it has started around them. By the time the chorus reaches the stage, the house has been claimed. The audience is inside New Harnomy.

The Curtain Call Problem

A satirical opera that ends on a cut-to-black has a curtain call problem. If the cast comes out smiling and bows, the satire collapses into performance and the audience goes home relieved. We cannot have that.

The solution is structural. After the eight-second blackout, house lights come up to full—not stage lights, house lights. The stage remains dark. There is no curtain call. The actors do not appear. There is only the audience, looking at each other, in the theater they paid to be in, with the chord still ringing in their ears.

After thirty seconds of this—long enough that some people start to stand, some start to clap uncertainly, some look at their programs—the cast walks out, in street clothes, from the wings, and takes seats in the front row of the house. They do not face the audience. They face the empty stage. They sit.

Only then does a single bow happen: Valencia, alone, from her seat, without rising, a small nod to the house.

The rest of the company never bows. They get up, in ones and twos, and walk out through the audience to the lobby. The audience is left to leave on their own timing, past the LYSTERIA Coalition table that is still staffed, past the PILF petition volunteer who asks if they'd like to sign on their way out.

Some people will sign. That is the point.

The production's final gesture is to refuse the applause it has earned, and to send the audience home implicated.

Design Coherence

Every design department must hold the Wildean line. The mauve of the Framework recurs in the lobby carpet, the ushers' lanyards, the program book itself—but never called out, never winked at. The portrait of Summer that rises in Act III should already be glimpsed, smaller, earlier: on a poster at the LYSTERIA table in the lobby, in the background of one of Pengold's office scenes, partially obscured at the festival. Its final ascension must feel like something the audience has been staring at without seeing for three hours.

Costume follows the same rule. No character is ever costumed as a joke. The bespoke revolutionary aesthetic for Dick, the professional-class activist tailoring for Summer, the mayoral gravitas for Pengold—all must be rendered with the same seriousness as any other world-premiere opera. The absurdity is in the gap between how the character sees themselves and what the audience sees. The costume closes that gap only by being completely sincere.

Valencia's costume is the exception that proves the rule: she is dressed in what actual working people actually wear. Not in theatrical "working class" drag. Real clothes. Practical clothes. Clothes that have been worn more than once this week.

The Load-Bearing Silences

Three silences hold the production together. Lose any of them and the opera collapses into ordinary satire.

The Twenty-Two Seconds: Pengold's silent reading at the top of the opera. This silence establishes that the evening will not flatter the audience with entertainment.

The Clarinet Line: Dick's "Pengold—you know me" against a thinned orchestra. This is not silence acoustically; it is silence dramatically. The stage listens to nothing. The fist closes here.

The Eight Seconds of Blackout: After the severed chord. This silence is where the opera deposits itself in the audience. Everything the production has built goes into this gap. Shortening it is not a technical compromise; it is an evisceration.

The stage manager who cuts any of these to "move the show" has not understood the show.